

## Spot-a-Geek Contest

Are you a true blue techie, or just another wannabe? Take this quiz and find out!

### ① John Carmack is...

- a. The forward in the American soccer team
- b. Just another guy named John
- c. The one true God
- d. Not as pretty as Killcreek

### ② If you are stranded on a desert island, and allowed only one possession. What would it be?

- a. My PC
- b. My girlfriend
- c. You mean I'd have to leave my chair?
- d. My PC, my girlfriend, my fridge... (Help! I can't count)

### ③ Your girlfriend caught you cheating on her, what do you do?

- a. Apologise with chocolates
- b. Ha, ha, that would never happen, I'm too smart
- c. Say it with flowers
- d. Ha, ha, that would never happen. Err... what's a girl?

### ④ You've inherited lots of money! What are you going to do with it?

- a. Put it in the bank
- b. Buy that cell phone I've been dreaming about!
- c. GeForce 4! Here I come!
- d. Donate it to charity

### ⑤ So you are invited to a formal event. What would you wear?

- a. My best tuxedo/dress
- b. My neighbour's best tuxedo/dress
- c. My black Gorillaz T-shirt and those torn jeans.
- d. Hey I told you—I am not leaving this chair!

spend much of their cash (thanks to the magic buy-sell cycle), they don't mind".

### More than just computers

But hardware does not begin and end with computers. There are other objects of desire, ranging from cell phones, to PDAs, MP3 players and game consoles. If it is shiny and requires a power source to run, you can bet these guys are interested. The case of Kinnar and Emily comes to mind. Ask him about gadgets though and his smile turns to an evil grin, as he removes his Nokia 7650 cell-phone. "Sexy isn't she? I just got her. It pays to have contacts! What I would really like to own is Sharp's Zaurus SL-5000—it's a PDA that runs Linux and Java applications. It has a very neat keyboard that slides out. I think I saw an ad

that offered the PDA free with a Linux development kit. Since I want it bad enough, I think I'll buy the kit, just to get at the Zaurus." Surprisingly, Kinnar isn't what you'd consider a geek; he just likes collecting shiny gadgets and naming them!

Not all gadgets are created equal, as Chris points out: "MP3 players are pieces of trash and a waste of money. You need 128 MB of RAM just to get an hour of good quality music on one of those. If I ever buy a compressed portable audio player it would have to be a Mini Disk. Right now I have a Sony Discman which does all I need it to do." And since he is a certified gamer, a console can't be far behind: "I considered a Nintendo Gameboy Advance (a handheld gaming console) but once I actually got to try one out, I dropped the idea—it wasn't very comfortable with the small buttons seated so close to each

other. The other consoles I have owned are the Nintendo Entertainment System, Sega Genesis, Sony PSOne and Nintendo Gameboy." But monetary problems forced Chris to make some sacrifices: "Right now I only have a Sega Dreamcast. I had to sell the others."

The conversation slowly tilts towards modding. "I have been considering a Dreamcast mod, but never got around to completing it. I wanted to shift the guts into a wooden case and put a 120 mm fan on the back. I opened it up and checked out the insides, the idea is quite possible," says Chris. One can only shake one's head in disbelief.

Utkarsh shares the console passion with Chris—he owns a Nintendo 64, a Sega Dreamcast, a Sony PlayStation 2 and more peripherals than you can shake a

stick at. He is also quite sad: "I had planned to go to my friend's place and check out the Xbox, but he bailed out on me. I really wanted to check it out." With the next generation of consoles raining down upon the gaming masses, lines have been drawn between the supporters and the opposition, and fights on the scale of Mahabharata, are not unheard of.

At the end of the day what will this fervour get them? The fact is that a gadget freak, by definition, knows the inner workings of his latest procurement—the theory behind its working and even the industrial trends that will dictate where his passion will take him six months from now. If tempered with the right professional training, a technology guru can go very far in this digital world. They make great engineers, professional technical help providers and assemblers. They can even work in the game development sector or teach at IT training centres. The avenues are limited only by their imagination.

So there you have them ladies and gentlemen—a race of individuals who set alarms on their gaming consoles, a breed that eats technology information over breakfast and laughs in the face of hardware problems. They are out there, trading in the latest gadgets that most of us can only dream of getting our hands on, let alone owning them. They will laugh at you, they will help you out, they will bug you with facts and figures on the rising trend of mobile handsets, and they will constantly surprise you with the amount of money that they spend on satiating their passion. Are you one of them? Stand up and be counted. ■

AHMED SHAIKH

## SCOREBOARD

| Question | a  | b  | c  | d  |
|----------|----|----|----|----|
| 1        | 10 | 5  | 15 | 20 |
| 2        | 15 | 5  | 20 | 10 |
| 3        | 10 | 15 | 5  | 20 |
| 4        | 10 | 15 | 20 | 5  |
| 5        | 5  | 10 | 15 | 20 |



**20-40:** You poor thing, you need help dialling a telephone.

**40-55:** Okay, so you can tell a cell phone from a PDA, but don't let it go to your head!

**55-70:** You think gadgets are cute, but only if they come in different colours, preferably polka-dotted.

**70-100:** You've won yourself a life long subscription to Digit. Send in your cheque for Rs 10,000 to...